

Pauline Hanson flies the flag harder than anyone. Look at what's happened to the house.

TL;DR: Hanson's whole brand is being the most pro-Australia person in the building. But judge patriotism the way we conservatives normally do — stewardship, responsibility, what actually survives on your watch — and her record runs against the country, not for it. Hear me out, because I'm not coming at this from the left.

Start with the principle we'd apply to anyone else. Loving your country isn't a flag in the front window. It's whether you maintain the house you were handed: keep the family under one roof, pay the debts, and don't let strangers tamper with the locks. By that test, how's she done?

She let foreigners reach for the locks. Our gun laws are a conservative inheritance — Howard's work, after Port Arthur, and one of the few things the centre-right is genuinely proud of. In 2018 her two most senior people, James Ashby and Steve Dickson, flew to Washington and asked the American gun lobby, the NRA included, for up to US\$20 million. The discussed point of the money was to win the balance of power and water those laws down. When Al Jazeera aired the tapes, Hanson didn't clean house — she called it a "political attack," said it was taken out of context, and her blokes blamed the booze. That's a patriot inviting a foreign lobby to help file down locks her own side installed.

Her household won't stay under the roof. Stewardship is proven by what survives, and her party keeps walking out the front door. Malcolm Roberts got disqualified by the High Court for being a British citizen — a sovereignty stuff-up inside a party that sells sovereignty. Culleton, Anning, Burston: all gone. Burston left after she flipped on the company tax cuts. That's not the establishment knifing her; that's a custodian who can't keep her own house in order.

She keeps dragging the family into brawls it has to clean up. Remember the "it's OK to be white" motion? She pulled 23 Coalition senators into voting for it before the government worked out what it had done and backflipped the next day, calling it an "error." The slogan, as the reporting and the researchers point out, comes straight out of white-supremacist forums — built to bait. She'll say she meant it as anti-racism, and fine. But the effect was to humiliate the actual centre-right and drag an American internet brawl onto the Senate floor. Same energy as the burqa stunt her own Attorney-General, George Brandis, called "appalling" — to a standing ovation. Theatre that costs her own side.

Now the honest part, because this sub will rightly pull me up if I skip it.

She isn't pointing at nothing. Hanson got traction because she named real things the major parties spent years ducking — the pace of immigration, social cohesion, the sense that the political class had stopped listening to ordinary people. Those are legitimate concerns, not prejudice, and plenty of decent people vote on them. She's even had the odd real win on the crossbench. If your bar is "did she say things Canberra didn't want said," she clears it easily.

But naming a problem isn't fixing it, and that's exactly where the brand and the record split. A real cause deserves a real steward. She turns genuine concern into permanent grievance and spectacle, can't hold a party together for a full term, flips on the economics, and will pick a fight with her own side — and cosy up to a foreign lobby — before she'll do the slow, unglamorous work of actually conserving anything. Flying the flag is the easy bit. Keeping the house is the job.

So, honest question for the room: if patriotism is stewardship — and for us it usually is — what, exactly, has Pauline Hanson conserved?